

political turmoil in the state. President's rule had been lifted in Jharkhand only five months ago, nearly a year after it was imposed in January 2009 to pave the way for the formation of a JMM-BJP government.

The BJP pulled the plug on Soren's government a day before the JMM chief had committed to step down to facilitate the formation of a BJP-led government. Though Soren had proposed the rotational sharing of chief ministership to appease the BJP, he consigned the deal to the dustbin within 48 hours of stitching it. According to the pact, BJP General Secretary Arjun Munda was to lead the government for the first 28 months.

By declaring withdrawal of support just after Soren voted against the Cut Motion in Parliament and then getting involved in a month-long negotiations with the Sorens, the BJP gave an impression of bending over backwards to capture Jharkhand's top seat. But the "party with a difference" lost its face in Jharkhand.

The BJP, however, can take heart from the fact that they are not the biggest losers in the "theatre of the absurd", as senior party leader Murli Manohar Joshi said. The drama also unfolded openings for everyone. For instance, Marandi, who had made it clear that he did not wish to touch the Sorens with a barge pole, was later found vacillating a bit.

Soren, with his spurious politics, has emerged as the biggest loser in Jharkhand. With his absolute yearnings for power and the methods he adopted at grabbing it, he today personifies the meaning of "by hook or by crook". He is also a father blindfolded by the unreasonable fascination to see his son rise. Ever since Soren was sworn in as Jharkhand chief minister for the third time on December 30, 2009, 35-year-old Hemant was widely known to be the *de facto* chief minister. Soren named Hemant as his political heir when he had him elected as the JMM's legislature party leader earlier this year. On more than one occasion, a vertical split in the party over Hemant was visible before his father prevented it.



**MUNDA (EXTREME RIGHT)
WITH SENIOR BJP LEADERS**



SIX YEARS, SIX RESIGNATIONS

JULY 2004 Resigns from Union Cabinet after a 30-year-old massacre case resurfaces

NOV 2004 Re-inducted into Union Cabinet

MARCH 2005 Quits from Cabinet to take over as chief minister. Resigns nine days later after failing to prove majority in the Assembly.

JAN 2006 Re-inducted into Union Cabinet

NOV 2006 Removed from the Cabinet after a Delhi court convicts him for murder

AUG 2007 Acquitted by Delhi High Court

AUG 2008 Takes over as Jharkhand chief minister

JAN 2009 Loses bypoll; quits

DEC 2009 Becomes Jharkhand chief minister

APRIL 2010 Votes against BJP's cut motion in Parliament

MAY 2010 Resigns after BJP withdraws support.

In fact, family intrigues and kinship rivalry precipitated the political crisis in Jharkhand. Even Hemant and Soren's widowed daughter-in-law Sita refused to vacate their assembly seats for the senior Soren, which almost ensured his exit from the chief minister's office even before he resigned. There was no affection between Sita, the widow of Shibu's elder son Durga, and Hemant, who is known for his Macbethian ambitions and the Judas touch.

But Soren still is a name to reckon with in Jharkhand politics and the wily politician still has the desire and determination to bounce back. And the only thing missing is perhaps what matters most—his credibility. Besides, his body appears to be finding it hard to translate his thoughts into action. A group of political observers now believe that the current spell of President's rule may mark the beginning of the end of Soren's political career. His chances of becoming chief minister for the fourth time seem very slim now. The UP leadership has already refused him a new stint in the Union Cabinet.

Soren must be a sad man. He wanted to catapult his son's career to the top before hanging his boots. Meanwhile, unmindful of the ideologies, the father-son duo is planning their next move. The Jharkhand chapter of political shenanigans is yet to see its end. ■